Matias
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Mastering
Excellence in sound

Mastering
HANDBOOK
Guide

HOW TO PREPARE AND SUBMIT YOUR MIXES FOR MASTERING

WWW.MATIASPARISIMASTERING.COM

The information contained here is designed to optimize the preparation of your mixes.

HOW TO SUBMIT YOUR MIX FOR MASTERING

The mix should be exported between -6 dB and -3 dB. Make sure not to apply any mastering-related processing on the master channel, such as using compressors or limiters. Ensure that the signal never exceeds 0 dBFS and does not generate clipping (saturation on the master output).

Reference Track

When submitting your mix, you may attach a commercial song you like or used as a guide during your production. In the mastering session, our engineer can import your reference to compare it with your processed mix and achieve your desired sound.

SAMPLE RATE AND BIT DEPTH

We recommend you maintain the same sample rate and bit depth with which you started your project. If your project is in 44.1 kHz, 48 kHz, or 96 kHz, export it at that same frequency to avoid unnecessary conversions.

Example: 44.100 Hz / 24 Bits

FILE FORMAT

- Export your final mix in WAV or AIFF format. These uncompressed formats preserve all the details of your audio.
- Do not send MP3, AAC, or other compressed formats! These formats discard audio information to reduce the file size, and we cannot restore that information during the mastering process.

SUBMISSION AND DELIVERY TIMES

01 Mix Name and Description

Artist Name - Song Name - MIX (Sample Rate and Bit Depth)

Example:
Matias Parisi - Mastering - MIX (44.1 Khz 24 Bits)

If there is more than one (1) file, they should be delivered in a folder (ZIP) named in the same manner.

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02 Submission Method

The mix can be sent via a link from www.wetransfer.com to the following email address: matiasparisimastering@gmail.com. You can also use a Google Drive link.

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03 Master Delivery Time

Once the material has been approved, a delivery date will be assigned depending on the number of songs. The average delivery time is 48 to 72 hours.

CHECKLIST FOR MIX SUBMISSION

To ensure the best final result, it's essential that your mix is as optimized as possible. This section details the most common issues we find in the pre-mastering stage. Considering these points will help you prepare your material to achieve the highest quality in the mastering process.

Excessive Sibilance and Aggressive De-essing

In case the production contains vocals, sibilance refers to the "s," "sh," and "ch" sounds, which can sound harsh and very high-pitched. The de-esser is a tool designed to attenuate these sounds.

Overly Compressed Dynamic Range

The dynamic range is the difference in level between the highest and lowest sections of an audio signal.

It represents a fundamental element of musical expression and the perceived impact of a production. If the mix arrives with an already limited dynamic range, it restricts our work during mastering. It is not possible to "restore" a dynamic range that has been eliminated in the mix.

Phase Issues

A mix with phase issues can sound diffused, unstable, or "too wide," losing its center and definition. (Low-frequency sounds can lose strength.) For this reason, it is important that the mix sounds good in both stereo and mono.

Clipping in the Mix

Clipping is a form of digital distortion that occurs when a mix's audio signal exceeds the maximum level of 0 dBFS (Decibels Full Scale).

The clipping in the mix compromises the audio quality from the start and turns the mastering engineer's work into a repair job instead of an optimization one. To avoid clipping, it is crucial that the level of the highest peaks of your mix does not exceed -3 dBFS. It is vital that you do not use a limiter on your main bus to increase the volume, as this creates a master with no headroom for us to work with.

Level Imbalance Between Stereo Channels

An optimal stereo mix should have a consistent and symmetrical level balance between the left and right channels. Correcting this problem in the master is more complex and less precise than solving it directly in the mix, where each element can be adjusted individually.

MASTER DELIVERY

01 Mastering for CD

This service focuses on delivering a final master that complies with Red Book specifications for the CD format. The process optimizes the signal for precise True Peak control, ensuring the digital integrity of the audio.

Mastering for Vinyl 02

This service adapts your music for physical playback on vinyl records. It focuses on the mono compatibility of low frequencies to ensure the material is in phase. This process guarantees a stable groove cut and high-quality playback, preventing the turntable's needle from skipping or damaging the record.

03 Mastering for Streaming Platforms

Mastering for streaming focuses on optimizing for loudness normalization. The goal is to deliver a master with controlled LUFS and True Peak levels, ensuring consistent playback and optimal performance on digital platforms.

What Volume Would You Like to Sound at?

We have the best equipment to achieve the sound you desire. Depending on the style and destination of the production, we can advise you on what volume to finish your production at.

What is LUFS and Why is it Important?

LUFS (Loudness Units Full Scale) is a measurement standard that unifies the perceived loudness of music. Unlike decibels (dB), which measure a signal's peak, LUFS measures a song's average loudness over time.

Even though normalization has unified volumes, the amount of compression and the LUFS level are still an artistic choice. A master with more dynamic range (lower LUFS) will have a more open sound and more "punch," while a more compressed master (higher LUFS) will sound more consistently loud.

LUFS LEVELS

-5 to -6 LUFS: Maximum spectral density. High perceived volume with an extreme reduction of dynamic range. Transient limiting results in a uniform output signal. This level focuses on maximum perceived loudness, at the expense of punch and dynamics.

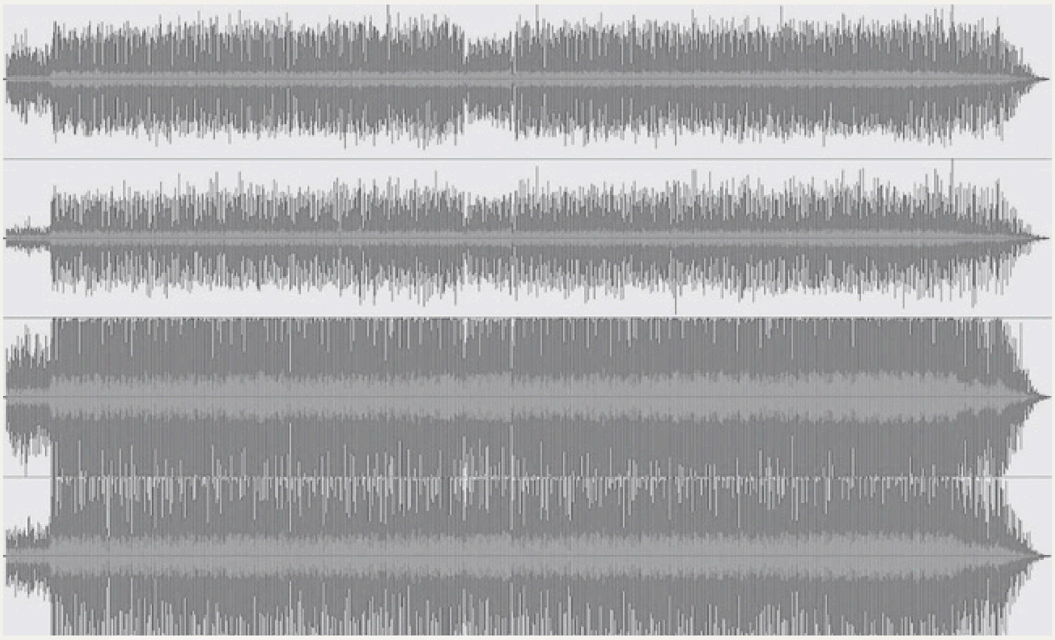
-7 to -8 LUFS: Very high loudness. Optimal balance between compression and transient response. The audio is compact and dense, but the percussive elements still retain a sense of impact.

-9 to -10 LUFS: Ample and spacious. It presents a dynamic range with notable sonic transparency. This allows the mix to preserve its dynamic range, which maintains a better balance between the instruments.

-11 to -12 LUFS: Medium loudness. Wide dynamic range and a sense of openness in the mix. Compression is used subtly to unify the instruments without sacrificing the contrast between sections. The result is a more organic sound.

-14 LUFS: Maximum fidelity and transparency. The perceived volume is low, but the dynamic range is wide and with little compression. The master virtually reflects the original dynamics of the recording. The volume relationship between the instruments and the feeling of a natural performance are preserved.

Visual Representation of the Relationship between Loudness and Dynamics



We hope this guide has been of great help to you in preparing your music. If you have any questions about the mastering process or your particular project, please don't hesitate to contact us.

Thank you very much for trusting our service!

Best regards,
Matias Parisi

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